given excellent guidance as to Soviet deployment methods, and has permitted detailed search of large areas of the USSR, including many previously suspected to contain missile complexes.'[8]

It had taken satellite technology several years to reach the point where such coverage was possible. This development became essential to the 'national technical means of verification' in the arms control treaties of the 1960s and 1970s. Various writers have suggested that the missile gap was debunked by the espionage of Oleg Penkovsky. His information did indeed prove accurate and was referred to in the NIE as 'reliable clandestine reports' that provided 'useful evidence on the general status and organisation of long range missile forces.'[9] However, it was the satellite (and electronic) intelligence that led to changes in the NIE.

As noted, the new assessment was then made public by the Pentagon in October 1961, effectively calling Khrushchev's bluff about Soviet superiority. Nevertheless, for NATO, once the Soviets could strike the United States, the credibility of the US commitment to use nuclear weapons against Soviet aggression against NATO was called into doubt. And the credibility of 'extended deterrence' became a preoccupation for the NATO alliance for the duration of the Cold War.

Khrushchev was bluffing about long-range missiles, though this did not prevent him from threatening Washington's allies. Moscow had done this before. In response to the British, French, and Israeli attack on Egypt in 1956, the Soviet Premier, Nikolai Bulganin, protested to the British Prime Minister, Anthony Eden, and asked: 'What situation would Britain find itself in if she were attacked by stronger states possessing all kinds of modern destructive weapons?'[10] There is no evidence the British government (nor the French or Israelis) paid any great heed to Bulganin's words, though Nikita Khrushchev believed (or at least told his colleagues) that the Soviet warning was decisive in ending the attack on Egypt.

In November 1961 Khrushchev accosted Sir Frank Roberts at the Bolshoi Theatre. He told him that Washington's European allies would not survive the first day of a nuclear war.[11] Khrushchev asked how many atomic bombs would it take to destroy the United Kingdom? The ambassador said six. Khrushchev told him the Soviet General Staff had earmarked 'scores' for